

Evaluate the Results

By now you’ve seen it yourself: AI makes mistakes. It uses the same confident voice whether the facts are right or wrong. So what do you do with an AI answer, knowing it might be wrong?

One option is to ignore AI. Pretend it doesn’t exist. Nobody who’s made it this far in the course is doing that: AI is too powerful to leave on the shelf. To **Be Smarter Than the Tool**, you need the right skills to evaluate AI’s results.

How you evaluate the results

STEP 1 Read

This might sound obvious, but weak AI users take AI’s output and pass it along without reading it. They share it with co-workers, drop it in a group chat, and hit send. Reading every word is the floor.

STEP 2 Understand

You’ll never know whether an answer is right if you don’t understand what it says. Sometimes your own knowledge gives you a complete, deep understanding. Other times it won’t be so clear. And the fastest explainer of an AI answer is often the same AI: “Explain the second paragraph in simpler terms” costs you one message.

STEP 3 Validate

As you read, hold the answer up against your own knowledge. A well-stocked brain is your fastest fact-checker, and this is where everything you’ve ever learned pays off.

But watch its limit: “Maria Petronoski won 3 gold medals at the 1932 Olympics in Athens” sounds perfectly fine. The 1932 Games were in Los Angeles, and she doesn’t exist. The more specific the detail, the more skeptical you should be. When a topic is beyond what you know, “sounds fine” isn’t validation. That’s what the Dig deeper steps below are for.

STEP 4 Decide: do you need to Dig deeper?

Two quick questions:

- **What kind of task was this?** Tasks that involve facts often need more evaluation. Work like a first draft or a brainstorm usually doesn’t: you’re just checking it against what you asked for. Did it cover everything you asked, in the shape you asked for it?
- **How much is riding on it?** Picking a movie for tonight: you’re done. A college essay, a health question, anything with your name on it: keep going.

STEP 5 Dig deeper

When Step 4 says to dig deeper, don’t just re-read the answer. Instead, interrogate the AI:

- **Ask AI for citations.** “Give me citations in your response.” You’ll see links within AI’s response that show where it got the information. Click those links. Read whether the page actually says what AI claims. If you can’t find the source, assume it doesn’t exist: AI frequently invents plausible-sounding citations.
- **Challenge the AI.** Ask it to argue the other side, or to flag what it’s least sure of.
- **Ask for a live web search.** AI’s built-in knowledge has a cut-off date, so on anything recent, have it check the live web.
- **Spot the “almost true” trap.** If part of an answer is verifiably true, don’t assume the rest is too.
- **Leave the chat.** Search the claim yourself, and take health, legal, or crisis questions to a real person.

If you had to do all five steps on every AI response, your day would disappear into evaluation. But that’s not the way it works. Read, understand, validate takes seconds, and **for most chats, you won’t need to dig deeper**. You’ll just chat away.

THEN MAKE YOUR MOVE

Every evaluation ends in one of three moves.

Use it

It passed your checks. Most answers end here. Read, understood, validated, done.

Fix it

Something’s off and you can name it. Say exactly what’s wrong in a follow-up: “cut the stat I never gave you,” “make it shorter.” Being specific about what’s wrong beats starting over.

Walk away

Wrong tool, or stakes too high. Do it yourself, or take it to a person who actually knows: a teacher, a doctor, a pro.

Know which answers deserve the dig.

Read. Understand. Validate.